

Sisterhood as a licensing configuration

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Abstract: The paper argues that Sisterhood needs to be admitted as a feature-licensing configuration, which is implemented through prominent feature sharing involved in labeling. The account proposed in the paper explains and unifies a number of phenomena, like indeterminate licensing, wh-movement in languages like English, the EPP, clitic-strong pronoun (and more generally strong/weak element) alternations, ordering of agreement effects, and certain Case effects. Traditional Spec-Head agreement is quite generally recast as licensing under Sisterhood (though not all relevant Sisterhood licensing involves traditional Spec-Head agreement). It is also shown that Sisterhood licensing and Agree licensing can occur in either order when the same head is involved in both.

Keywords: agreement, EPP, indeterminates, multiple wh-fronting, pronouns, wh-movement

1. Introduction

One of the main issues in syntactic theory concerns licensing of syntactic features. In the Government and Binding theory (GB), syntactic licensing was assumed to take place under government. In the current theory, different types of operations and configurations are assumed for such licensing.

The most permissive locality-wise is unselective binding (often assumed to hold between C and wh-phrases in wh-in-situ languages, with the C unselectively binding wh-phrases in situ). Such licensing occurs at a distance, without locality constraints (apart from c-command).

Licensing via Agree (Chomsky 2000, 2001) is more restrictive. It also occurs at a distance, but its locality is constrained by the Phase Impenetrability Condition (PIC, though see Bošković 2007) and intervention effects, neither of which holds for unselective binding.

Spec-Head agreement (SHA), which was assumed to be the licensing configuration in early minimalism but got given up on essentially for theoretical (not empirical) reasons (see Chomsky 2000), is even more local than Agree, the elements involved in the relation in question being located in the same phrase. SHA is still appealed to for empirical reasons. In fact, the very fact (see e.g. Baker 2008, 2011, Franck, Lassi, Frauenfelder, and Rizzi 2006) that agreement is more likely to be realized morphologically if it involves a traditional SHA relation than agreement at a distance (e.g. SV order results in agreement in Fiorentino, but VS order, where the subject stays in situ, results in default agreement, see (1)) suggests that SHA may be needed independently of Agree, since the tendency is difficult to account for with Agree alone.

- (1) a. Le ragazze l' **hanno** telefonato.
the girls CL.3PL **have** phoned
'The girls have telephoned.'
b. Gli **ha** telefonato delle ragazze
CL.3M.SG **has** telephoned some girls
'Some girls have telephoned'
(Campos 1997)
(Brandi and Cordin 1989)

There are a number of other arguments for SHA in the literature, to mention just two of them here (for additional arguments, see e.g. Franck et al 2006, Bošković 2024, Koopman 2006): the Lobeck (1990) and Saito and Murasugi (1990) generalization that functional heads can license ellipsis of their complement only if they undergo Spec-Head agreement (SHA) and Baker's (2008, 2011) amply

motivated observation that while Agree at a distance suffices for number and gender features, person features require a Spec-Head configuration.¹

This paper will resurrect SHA, but in a very different form. I argue that in some cases, licensing requires Sisterhood (for general importance of sisterhood, see also Epstein 1999). SHA will be seen as a case of that sort, but I will also show that there are cases of Sisterhood licensing that do not involve SHA, which means that Sisterhood is not simply recasting of SHA. The main case concerns *indeterminates*, which will be discussed in the next section. Before turning to indeterminates, note that it is not surprising that Sisterhood is important to syntactic feature-licensing, as will be argued here. Thus, it is involved in c-command, you command what you are merged with (see Epstein 1999), which is your sister (and what it dominates). Sisterhood is also how every element enters the structure—it is not surprising that it is important; in fact, the discussion in this paper will indicate that the role of Sisterhood is even more pervasive than previously believed.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 discusses licensing of indeterminates, proposing a Sisterhood licensing account that is extended to wh-movement, the EPP, and more generally traditional Spec-Head agreement. Section 3 applies the account to a number of agreement paradigms and the Person Case Constraint. Section 4 does this with respect to clitic/strong pronoun alternations (as well as the strong/weak auxiliary alternation). Section 5 discusses Case licensing and section 6 addresses some more general issues that the proposed system raises. Section 7 concludes the paper.

2. Unifying indeterminate licensing, wh-movement, and the EPP

2.1. Indeterminates

In many languages, the forms that are used for wh-words have a variety of usages, like existentials, universal quantifiers, negative concord/NPIs, free choice, depending on the context in which they occur (see e.g. Haspelmath 1997). They are called indeterminates since their quantificational force is not inherently determined: it is determined by the licensing context in which they occur. Chinese examples in (2) illustrate this. In (1a), the indeterminate licenser is the +wh-C and in (1b), the negation: the licensing can take place at a distance, and one licenser can license more than one indeterminate: it seems safe to assume that the licensing here takes place via unselective binding.

- (2) a. ni xiang mai **shenme** ne?
 you want buy what Q
 ‘What do you want to buy?’
 b. wo bu xiang mai **shenme**.
 I not want buy anything
 ‘I don’t want to buy anything.’

Serbo-Croatian (SC) has a very different type of indeterminates, where addition of an inseparable affix to a wh-phrase results in the series of meanings shown in (3). There is a morphological subset-superset relation between the wh and other usages, referred to as *sub-wh system* (4).

¹As an illustration, in Icelandic nominative object constructions, the verb agrees with the nominative object at a distance (not SHA); crucially, while it agrees with the object in number, it cannot in person—it must bear the default 3 person (see (i)). Baker also shows that the generalization in question is responsible for why crosslinguistically adjectives show agreement in number and gender, but not in person.

(i) a. Henni leiddust beir.
her.DAT was.bored.by.3pl they.NOM
'She was bored with them.'

(Taraldsen 1995:307)

b. *Henni leiddumst við.
her.DAT was.bored.by.1pl we.NOM
'She was bored with us.'

(Taraldsen 1995:308)

(3) a. *ko* ‘who’ b. *iko* ‘anyone’ c. *niko* ‘no one’ d. *neko* ‘someone’ e. *svako* ‘everyone’ f. *bilo ko* ‘whoever’

(4) sub-wh system: *who*+X for other pronouns (inseparable, fully productive, order does not matter)

Also relevant is multiple wh-fronting (MWF). Bošković (2025a) identifies 18 MWF languages, Polish, Russian, SC, Romanian, Bulgarian, Macedonian, Czech, Slovenian, Ukrainian, Yiddish, Lithuanian, Hungarian, Basque, Mohawk, Georgian, Ossetic, Svan, and Latin. It turns out that they all have something in common, in particular, they all have a fully productive sub-wh system. This means that a sub-wh system is a prerequisite for MWF, as stated in (5).

(5) If a language has multiple wh-fronting, it has a sub wh-system.

This was illustrated above with SC in (3). Additional confirmations of (5) are provided by the MWF languages in (6)–(9) (the data in (6)–(12) are from, or based on, Haspelmath 1997; only partial paradigms are given, and not all series are illustrated).²

(6) Russian	interrogative	existential	neg-concord	free choice
person	<i>kto</i>	<i>kto-to</i>	<i>ni-kto</i>	<i>kto ugodno</i>
thing	<i>čto</i>	<i>čto-to</i>	<i>ni-čto</i>	<i>čto ugodno</i>
place	<i>gde</i>	<i>gde-to</i>	<i>ni-gde</i>	<i>gde ugodno</i>
time	<i>kogda</i>	<i>kogda-to</i>	<i>ni-kogda</i>	<i>kogda ugodno</i>
manner	<i>kak</i>	<i>kak-to</i>	<i>ni-kak</i>	<i>kak ugodno</i>

(7) Bulgarian	interrogative	existential	neg-concord	free choice
person	<i>koj</i>	<i>nja-koj</i>	<i>ni-koj</i>	<i>koj to i da e</i>
thing	<i>što</i>	<i>nja-što</i>	<i>ni-što</i>	<i>što to i da e</i>
place	<i>kâde</i>	<i>nja-kâde</i>	<i>ni-kâde</i>	<i>kâde to i da e</i>
time	<i>koga</i>	<i>nja-koga</i>	<i>ni-koga</i>	<i>koga to i da e</i>
manner	<i>kak</i>	<i>nja-kak</i>	<i>ni-kak</i>	<i>kak to i da e</i>

(8) Hungarian	interrogative	existential	neg-concord	free choice
person	<i>ki</i>	<i>vala-ki</i>	<i>sen-ki</i>	<i>akár-ki</i>
thing	<i>mi</i>	<i>vala-mi</i>	<i>sem-mi</i>	<i>akár-mi</i>
place	<i>hol</i>	<i>vala-hol</i>	<i>se-hol</i>	<i>akár-hol</i>
time	<i>mikor</i>	<i>vala-mikor</i>	<i>sem-mikor</i>	<i>akár-mikor</i>
manner	<i>hogy(an)</i>	<i>vala-hogy(an)</i>	<i>se-hogy(an)</i>	<i>akár-hogy(an)</i>

(9) **Basque**
interrogative bait-series(non-emphatic) *i*-series(NPI) *edo*-series(free choice) *nahi*(f. choice)

Person	<i>nor</i>	<i>nor-bait</i>	<i>i-nor</i>	<i>edo-nor</i>	<i>nor-nahi</i>
Thing	<i>zer</i>	<i>zer-bait</i>	<i>i-zer</i>	<i>edo-zer</i>	<i>zer-nahi</i>
Place	<i>non</i>	<i>non-bait</i>	<i>i-non</i>	<i>edo-non</i>	<i>non-nahi</i>
Time	<i>noiz</i>	<i>noiz-bait</i>	<i>i-noiz</i>	<i>edo-noiz</i>	<i>noiz-nahi</i>
Manner	<i>nola</i>	<i>nola-bait</i>	<i>i-nola</i>	<i>edo-nola</i>	<i>nola-nahi</i>
Determiner	<i>zein</i>	-	-	<i>edo-zein</i>	<i>zein-nahi</i>

²German doesn’t have a productive sub-wh system since in German only one series is related to wh-words; note, however, that (5) is a one-way correlation, for an additional factor that is relevant to MWF, see Bošković 2025a).

Note that English does not have a sub wh-system: the relevant system is not productive but lexicalized, e.g. *somewhere/nowhere/anywhere* but **somewho/nowho/anywho*; Cheng (1991) suggests that the good cases are lexically incorporated forms, essentially compounds.

Particularly informative is Romance. Latin was a MWF language (Ledgeway 2012, Dadan 2019) and had a fully productive sub-wh system. This fully productive sub-wh system got lost in all modern Romance languages except one: Romanian. Importantly, Romanian is the only modern Romance language that still has MWF, which strongly confirms (5). A partial illustration of the Romance situation is given in (10)–(12).

(10) Latin	interrogative	existential	polarity	free choice
person	quis	ali-quis	quis-quam	qui-vis
thing	quid	ali-quid	quid-quam	quid-vis
place	ubi	ali-cubi	usquam	ubi-vis
(11) Italian	interrogative	existential		neg-concord
person	chi	qualcuno		nessuno
thing	che	qualche cosa, qualcosa		niente, nulla
place	dove	in qualche luogo		in nessun luogo
(12) Romanian	interrogative	existential	free choice	oare-series
person	cine	cine-va	ori-cine	oare-cine
thing	ce	ce-va	ori-ce	oare-ce
place	unde	unde-va	ori-unde	oare-unde

A sub-wh system is thus a pre-requisite for MWF.

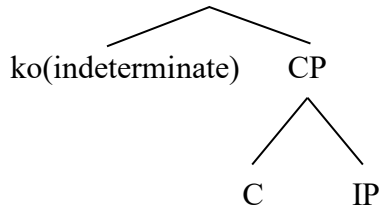
Returning to the comparison of SC and Chinese, SC has a very different type of indeterminate system from Chinese and what is curious about that system is that it is related to MWF. Putting aside the wh-usage for a moment, in contrast to Chinese, in SC indeterminate licensing clearly does not take place at a distance. What is needed for indeterminate licensing in SC is sisterhood: the licensing particle is a sister to the indeterminate, as illustrated by e.g. *i+ko* ‘anyone’, where *i* is the licensing particle and *ko* the indeterminate.

What about the wh-usage? The crucial point is that *ko* in (3) actually does not correspond to English *who*. The form is a true indeterminate; since it does not have an inherent quantificational force, it requires licensing, which also determines its quantificational force. Normally, the particles that indeterminates merge with do that in SC (in a sisterhood relationship). In a sub-wh system, the only usage on which the indeterminate is not merged with a licensing element is the wh-usage, which means that in the base position, we are dealing here with an unlicensed indeterminate. The suggestion is that this is what requires fronting: the indeterminate is licensed as a wh-phrase by moving to merge with an interrogative projection (this will be implemented below in more detail). The movement thus does not take place because of a property of the interrogative head (as in English, see below), but because of indeterminate licensing—this is why they all need to undergo fronting, which results in MWF. Importantly, the licensing is still done under Sisterhood, since the sister of the indeterminate is a +wh-projection/element (see (13)). All indeterminate licensing in SC is thus done through Sisterhood.³

³The same form that is used in wh-questions receives a non-wh interpretation in wh-existentials, like (i) (see e.g. Bošković 2002, Izvorski 1998, Šimík 2011).

(i) a. Ima ko šta da ti proda.
has who what that you sells

(13)



Summarizing the discussion in this section so far, indeterminate licensing in SC takes place under Sisterhood, which is not the case in Chinese (this is also responsible for SC being a MWF language).

Interestingly, Japanese has an indeterminate system which is in a way a mixture of Chinese and SC. Japanese has licensing particles, where sometimes the licenser is a sister of the indeterminate and sometimes the licensing is done at a distance. There are three patterns: on the existential usage, the licensing particle must be the sister (as in SC), and on the interrogative it never is (as in Chinese). Particle *-mo* (found with NPIs), on the other hand, can either be the sister to the indeterminate or detached from it. The last case is illustrated below:

- (14) a. *Daremo* ringo-o tabe-nak-atta b. John-wa [[*dare-ga* susumeta] hon]-*mo* yomanakatta.
anyone apple-ACC eat-neg-past John-TOP who-NOM recommend book-also didn't.read
'No one ate an apple' 'John didn't read the books that anyone recommended'

Importantly, Japanese used to be a MWF language (Aldridge 2009, Dadan 2019). It is no longer a MWF language, which means that licensing can be done at a distance now, as in Chinese (recall that MWF is

'There is someone who can sell you something.'

b. **Ima ko da ti proda šta.*

(SC)

Importantly, the relevant elements still must front here. The fronting does not take place to an interrogative projection—the relevant clause is simply not interrogative. Bošković (2025a) suggests that since *ko* and *šta* are not merged with an indefinite particle in these cases, they are licensed as indefinites by moving to a special indefinite-licensing position. Note in this respect Kaqchikel, where the exact same form functions as interrogative or indefinite, and must front on both functions, with the landing site of the interrogative higher than the indefinite licensing projection, as Erlewine (2016) shows. Kaqchikel shows that there is a pattern where the indefinite meaning of an indeterminate is licensed by movement to a special projection that licenses this meaning. This is then what happens in (i) (the movement is not to the interrogative CP since the relevant clause is clearly not interrogative; note that this can also be taken as a confirmation that the relevant elements are not inherently wh-phrases but bare indeterminates).

Note also that D-linked wh-phrases need not front. For an explanation why, see Bošković (2025a), who, taking advantage of the fact that indeterminate pronouns are normally non-specific while D-linked ones (i.e. D-linked wh-phrases) are not, argues that the interpretation of the latter is essentially determined by their semantics, no further licensing is needed.

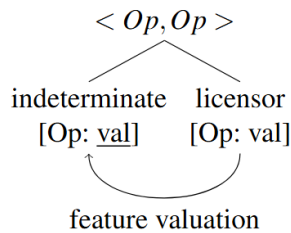
Note also that in very restricted semantic contexts (e.g. conditional antecedents, imperatives, strong epistemics), bare indeterminates can be interpreted as existentials in Slavic. Zanon (2025) argues that the relevant elements are licensed by a semantically motivated null operator, which I assume plays the role of the licensing affixes discussed above hence this analysis of the usage in question can be readily incorporated into the current system. Bošković (2025a) also suggests an alternative where an indeterminate that does not have a licensing particle attached and does not move to an indeterminate-licensing projection is interpreted by a default rule for unlicensed indeterminates, which applies in the relevant contexts in the languages that allow this usage (they also differ regarding such contexts), as a simple indefinite. Note that such indefinites cannot occur in wh-questions, which confirms the default nature of the licensing in question—it is available only if another way isn't, i.e. if a projection where an indeterminate can get licensed through movement is not present. (Note also that these indefinites are different from those in wh-existentials in many respects, e.g. the former cannot coordinate (Zanon 2025), while the latter can (Bošković 2025a)).

a result of Sisterhood licensing); I suggest that the Sisterhood licensing cases are a remnant of the Japanese-as-a-MWF-language system. (Interestingly, the always-at-the-distance case parallels the one that must involve movement in SC (the interrogative usage), which may not to be an accident).

Several authors have argued that the licensing particle is actually always generated with the indeterminate in Japanese, but is allowed to move away from the indeterminate (even for the Q-particle, see Hagstrom 1998, Cable 2010).⁴ The movement away is apparently disallowed in SC/MWF languages. Why is that the case? I turn now to the answer to that question.

I implement the sisterhood-licensing requirement in terms of Chomsky's (2013) feature-sharing involved in labeling, which actually also involves a sisterhood relation and where valuation is part of the feature-sharing that enables labeling. Since it does not have an inherently specified quantificational force, the indeterminate has an unvalued Op feature. The corresponding feature of the licensor is valued (as +wh, +neg, +universal quantification...). The licensor values the Op feature of the indeterminate, as a result of which the indeterminate and the licensor have exactly the same prominent feature that enables labeling. All this is illustrated in (15).

(15) Sisterhood licensing implemented via feature-sharing



Given the “damaging” effect of traces on feature-sharing/labeling (Chomsky 2013, 2015), neither element can then move away.⁵

Interestingly, this is also reminiscent of Criterial Freezing (Rizzi 2006). The kind of features involved in indeterminate licensing are in fact exactly the kind of features involved in Criterial Freezing.

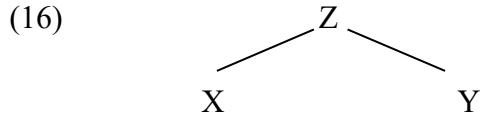
⁴Cable (2010) actually uses two options for the Q-particle, particle movement and its base-generation in CP.

It is worth noting that a number of Australian languages, like Martuthunira and Panyjima, have the same form for wh-phrases and indefinites but while the morphology is the same the syntax is not: they must front as wh-phrases, as indefinites they stay in situ (they cannot be checked for MWF since they disallow multiple questions, for discussion of these languages, see Cheng 1991, Bošković 2025a). Under the particle movement analysis, there is an interesting parallel here with particles in Japanese. The existential-licensing particle is actually the same as the question-licensing one morphologically (-ka). The former cannot move away, while the latter must. So, there is the same situation regarding movement as in the Australian languages in question, the only difference is that in the latter the indeterminate moves, and in the former the particle moves (the Australian languages don't have the licensing particle so that option is trivially unavailable. It is possible that the economy-of-derivation requirement to carry as little material as possible under movement (e.g. Bošković 2004, Chomsky 1995) favors particle movement over the movement of the indeterminate+particle complex if the former is in principle available.)

⁵Feature-sharing should not take place before particle movement. In this respect, Bošković (2008, in press) argues that feature-sharing has a freezing effect on movement, which will block particle movement if the particle undergoes feature-sharing (if the particle first moves and then feature-sharing is attempted, the issue is that traces cannot participate in feature-sharing).

There is another way to block particle movement. Bošković (in press) argues that a moving element must have an unvalued feature (uK), and that such features block feature-sharing and labeling (what this system achieves is that all movement is driven by labeling problems). If the particle were to move away then, it would have to have a uK, which would then prevent it from undergoing feature-sharing with the indeterminate that is necessary for indeterminate licensing. Note also that what is needed for indeterminate licensing is not simply Sisterhood, but licensing through prominent feature sharing (which does take place in a sisterhood relation).

Importantly, Rizzi (2016) argues that in a criterial freezing configuration that involves merger of X and Y (see (16)), neither X nor Y can undergo further movement, only the resulting object, Z in (16), can:



Applied to our case, this means that neither the indeterminate (X in (16)), nor the licensing particle (Y) can undergo movement (the whole complex, Z, can). This prevents licensing-particle movement in SC, in contrast to Japanese, where indeterminate licensing under sisterhood, i.e. the scenario discussed above for SC, is no longer enforced (as it is in MWF languages), hence licensing under unselective binding by the particle is possible if the particle moves away (or is base-generated at a distance, see fn 4).

Note also that SC nominal (and verbal) morphology is quite generally synthetic/fusional; e.g. in nominal concord, it is impossible to separate case and (different) phi-features, as the partial paradigm below illustrates:

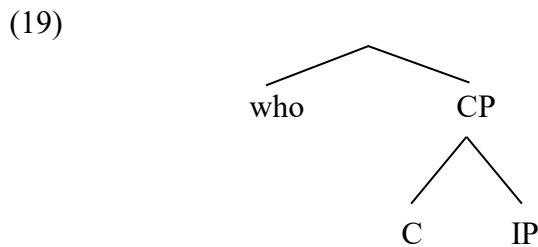
(17) *tall girl*: visokoj djevojci (datF.sg) visoku djevojku (accF.sg) visokim djevojkama (datF.pl) visoke djevojke (accF.pl), visoke djevojke (nomFpl)

(18) *tall boy*: visokom momku (datM.sg) visokog momka (accM.sg) visokim momcima (datM.pl) visoke momke (accM.pl) visoki momci (nomMpl)

The morphology involved in indeterminate licensing is agglutinative, which is a departure from the general morphological behavior of the language. The above analysis provides a reason for this departure, i.e. for why the language essentially does not behave like itself in this case.

2.2. Wh-movement in English

All this can be extended to a number of traditional Spec-Head agreement cases, reanalyzing them as Sisterhood licensing. Consider e.g. wh-movement in English. The suggestion is that the Op feature is unvalued on the C, but valued as +wh on the wh-phrase. This is natural since in English, the wh-phrase is not an indeterminate, which means that it has an inherent interrogative quantificational force.⁶ After wh-movement, the valuation and feature-sharing occur under sisterhood in English, exactly as in SC, including the case of SC wh-fronting. As in the case of SC wh-fronting, in English one element has an unvalued Op feature, with the other one the Op feature is valued as +wh. The licensing configuration is the same: Sisterhood (this is the reanalysis of traditional Spec-head agreement), the only difference between SC and English is which element has a valued and which has an unvalued Op feature.



⁶This differs from Chomsky (2013), where the Q feature of C is valued, and the corresponding feature of a wh-phrase is unvalued, but Chomsky was not concerned with the “determinate”/indeterminate distinction).

All this also deduces the effect of C having an edge feature in Chomsky (2008). There is no need to posit an edge feature for the C to enable wh-movement in English. What drives wh-movement now, i.e. the reason why wh-movement is needed in English, is the need of the C to undergo licensing (and valuation) in a sisterhood relation. Notice also that in English, it is the target that has the unvalued feature. As a result, it suffices that only one wh-phrase moves. This is in contrast to SC, where what is traditionally considered wh-phrases have the unvalued Op feature, hence they all have to move.⁷

To sum up, wh-movement in English involves licensing under Sisterhood. The implementation differs from SC in a way that ensures that in SC all wh-phrases move while only one moves in English. What's important is that, in contrast to SC, wh-phrases in English have an inherent interrogative quantificational force, they are not indeterminates. The analysis is stated in terms of Chomsky's (2013) feature-sharing involved in labeling, where crucially, valuation is part of the feature-sharing that enables labeling.⁸

2.3. Other cases of Spec-Head agreement: the EPP

Traditional Spec-Head agreement can in fact be quite generally reanalyzed as licensing under Sisterhood, i.e. the analysis of wh-movement presented above can be straightforwardly extended to other cases that involve traditional Spec-Head agreement, resurrecting (and recasting) the traditional Spec-Head agreement in terms of Sisterhood licensing (with feature-sharing involved in the relevant licensing, which makes sense given that feature-sharing in fact also involves a sisterhood relation).

Consider e.g. how the traditional EPP requirement, stated in terms of Spec-Head agreement in early minimalism (and later in terms of an edge requirement), can be implemented in this respect. Bošković (2007) argues Case-licensing requires the nominal to c-command its licensor, this being the reason why the nominal moves to SpecTP (the movement generally ends up creating the traditional Spec-head relation, note that Bošković 2007 argues that given the Case-licensing requirement, the traditional EPP can be eliminated⁹). This can be easily restated in the current system: following Bošković (2011), the

⁷Following Chomsky (2008), I assume that Merge is in principle free. In a single wh-question in English, the wh-phrase can move or not, but if it does not move, the unvalued feature of the C, which requires Sisterhood licensing, won't get valued. In SC, on the other hand, unless all wh-phrases move in a multiple wh-question, their unvalued feature will not get valued. (The Free Merge system in general needs to assume that English does not allow pronunciation of more than one wh-phrase in SpecCP (see also Pesetsky 2000), though see Bošković (2007) for a suggestion that deduces this from semantic considerations. Assuming necessity of Higginbotham & May's (1981) absorption for proper interpretation of multiple questions, the suggestion made there is that multiple wh-phrases located in SpecCPs (not in-situ) in English cannot undergo absorption, whereas this is possible in languages like Bulgarian. Multiple wh-fronting questions in English are then ruled out for semantic rather than syntactic reasons, the gist of the analysis essentially being that only moved indeterminates are allowed to undergo absorption).

⁸From the current perspective, there is an interesting possibility for V-2 in Germanic, where the element in SpecCP can be wh, topic, focus... All these elements move to C (i.e. merge with CP), and can be taken to value the C differently. There is then only one V-2 C, which is unvalued, and ends up being a +wh, +topic, or +focus head, as a result of valuation, with the Sisterhood valuation driving the V-2 movement to SpecCP (i.e. the C attracts these elements because it is unlicensed/unvalued, requiring Sisterhood valuation. The analysis may even be appropriate for English if topicalization is handled in terms of CP recursion (so topic movement also lands in SpecCP).)

⁹The work in question also argues that a number of cases that were argued to involve Case-licensing "at a distance" in the literature were misanalyzed.

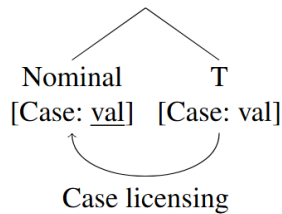
To mention here one argument for the obligatoriness of Case movement from Bošković (2007), consider (i):

(i) *I know what it seems (clear).

Seem does not assign Case. Why can't *know* Case-license *what* in (i) given that it has the ability to do that? In Chomsky's (2000, 2001) Agree approach, nothing prevents establishment of a probe-goal relation between the matrix *v* and *what* in (i), which should result in the Case-licensing of *what*. In Bošković (2007), this derivation is blocked because *what* with its uCase feature must function as a probe—it must c-command the matrix *v*. The only

nominal has an unvalued Case feature, and T has a valued Case feature. The Case feature of the nominal requires Sisterhood licensing, hence the nominal moves to merge with the TP. This is then another case of traditional Spec-Head agreement that can be recast in terms of Sisterhood licensing.

(20)



Chomsky's (2015) suggestion that a nominal must move to merge with TP because T is too weak to label can also be incorporated into the current system, in terms of TP needing Sisterhood licensing. In fact, more generally, Chomsky's (2015) strengthening for labeling can be recast in terms of Sisterhood: after a weak head in Chomsky's (2015) sense enters the structure, it requires Sisterhood licensing.

In the following section, the analysis developed above will be applied to a number of rather intricate agreement paradigms, which will provide evidence that both Sisterhood and Agree are needed, with specific ordering effects between the two when the same head is involved in both. ??The Agree+Sisterhood analysis will also enable us to simplify previous analyses that did not rely on Sisterhood agreement licensing.

3. Ordering between Agree and Sisterhood

Interestingly, there is evidence that Sisterhood licensing and Agree licensing can occur in either order, where in some cases Agree precedes Sisterhood and in others Sisterhood precedes Agree when the same head is involved in both, which in turn provides strong evidence that both are needed. Below, I will present some representative cases of both.

3.1. Agree > Sisterhood

There is an argument for an Agree>Sisterhood ordering based on Béjar and Řezáč's (2009) analysis of whether the absolutive agreement is controlled by External Argument (EA) or Internal Argument (IA) in Basque. In Basque, when the IA is [1p] or [2p] it controls absolutive agreement (21a,b,c). But when the IA is [3p] and EA is [1p] or [2p], the absolutive morpheme is controlled by the EA (21d).

- | | | |
|------|---|-----------------------|
| (21) | <i>Basque</i> | <i>EA</i> → <i>IA</i> |
| a. | ikusi <u>z</u> -in-t-u-da-n
seen 2-x-PL-have-1-PST
'I saw <u>you</u> .' | $1 \rightarrow 2 = 2$ |
| b. | ikusi <u>n</u> -ind-u-en
seen 1-x-have-PST | $3 \rightarrow 1 = 1$ |

way this can be done is if *what* moves to the matrix SpecvP but *what* would then move outside of its scope (embedded CP), which is disallowed (see Saito 1992).

Note *v* can in principle enter into an Agree relation with an NP in an interrogative SpecCP in cases like (ii).

(ii) I know what John bought.

In Innu-aimûn (Branigan and MacKenzie 2002), Passamaquoddy (Bruening 2001), and Tsez (Polinsky and Potsdam 2001), a verb can show object agreement with a *wh*-phrase in SpecCP (*know* can agree with *what* in (ii)). In contrast to (i), in such cases, the *wh*-phrase is Case-checked within the embedded clause. The matrix *v* can then undergo Agree with the *wh*-phrase; there is no need to move the *wh*-phrase to a position c-commanding the *v*.

- ‘He saw me.’
 c. ikusi n-ind-u-zu-n 2→1 = 1
 seen 1-x-have-2-PST
 ‘You saw me.’
 d. ikusi n-u-en 1→3 = 1
 seen 1-have-PST
 ‘I saw him.’

Béjar and Řezáč (2009) propose that in Basque, probe on *v* requires a 1/2 person feature (i.e. [part] feature in Harley and Ritter’s 2002 hierarchy). The probe first searches its c-command domain for an IA that has [1/2p]; if it fails, the probe then checks its Spec for whether the EA has [1/2p] (the Cyclic Agree analysis). Put differently, in current terms, Basque’s *v* head can agree with an argument both under Agree and under Sisterhood, with an ordering of Agree>Sisterhood. Evidence for the ordering comes from (21c): when both EA and IA have person features, the IA controls absolutive agreement.

Another case of Agree>Sisterhood ordering, which is similar to the Basque one but with an additional twist that can be readily accommodated in the current system, comes from Enxet Sur (Enlhet-Enenlhet) (for relevant data, which will only be summarized below, see Elliott 2021, Johnson 2025). The language has subject agreement except when the object is [1p], then agreement is controlled by the object and expresses [1, sg/pl]. Importantly, when the subject controls agreement, the agreement morphology is richer, it is sensitive to the subject’s [gender], [number], and [person] features.

Johnson (2025) analyzes this pattern in terms of Béjar and Řezáč’s Cyclic Agree, where the probe on *v* first searches down for an argument that is [1p] but if this fails, it then probes the EA in SpecvP. Importantly, while *v*’s probe is initially specified to look **only for** [1p], upon failing to find it, the probe somehow relaxes its interaction condition to just be anything with phi-features. The probe on *v* then agrees in person/number/gender with the subject in SpecvP. The “relaxation” raises an obvious question given that we are supposed to be dealing here with the same kind of an agreement operation.

In the current system, *v* first searches via Agree for a [1p] argument; if that fails *v* undergoes agreement via Sisterhood with the EA in SpecvP, i.e. we have an Agree>Sisterhood ordering. Furthermore, Sisterhood agreement is richer than Agree agreement, which is what we have seen before (cf. (1)), and which is more straightforwardly accommodated in the current system since we have different agreement mechanisms.

I turn now to the cases where Agree precedes Sisterhood when the same head is involved in both.

3.2. Sisterhood > Agree

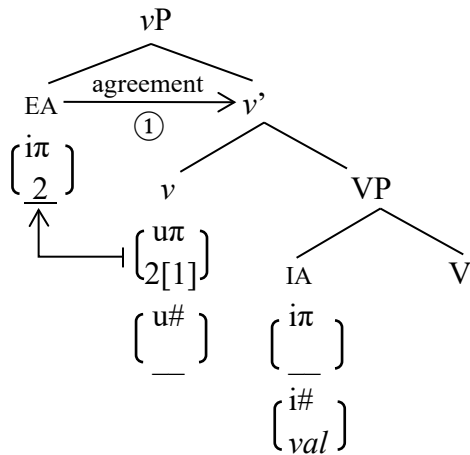
Some languages, like Lummi, show a Weak Person Case Constraint (PCC) type effect regarding external (EA) vs. internal (IA) arguments: if there is a 3rd person clitic it must be the internal argument (3person EA with 1/2person IE is impossible):

(22) Lummi [*Salish*]:

- a. xč̣i-t -Ø { -sən / -sxʷ / -s }
 know-TR -3.O {-1.SU/ -2.SU/ 3.SU.ERG }
 ‘I/you/he knows him. 1/2/3.EA > 3.IA
 b. xč̣i-t -oŋəs -sən
 know-TR 1/ 2.O -1.SU
 ‘I know you.’ 1.EA > 2.IA
 c. * xč̣i-t -oŋəs -əs

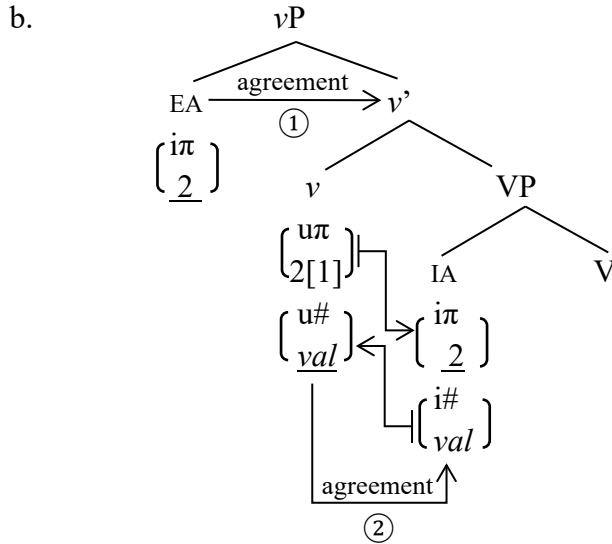
As with weak PCC with IO/DO, person valuation of the EA here bleeds person valuation of the IA. Importantly, to get the bleeding effect, valuation of the EA in SpecvP must occur before v probes down the IA. Essentially following Stegovec (2019), adapting it to the current system,¹⁰ the pattern can be accounted for as follows: As in Stegovec's account of regular PCC effects, pronouns are unvalued for person, and valued for number/gender; v is valued for person and unvalued for number/gender. Crucially, the EA in SpecvP must undergo agreement with v/vP before v probes IA. The EA merges to SpecvP, which means that it merges with vP, and immediately agrees with vP (which has the same features that v has) under Sisterhood to value its person feature (see ① in (23a); v' is actually vP at the point of merger). As in Stegovec's account of weak PCC (this is in fact the gist of his account of weak PCC), the pronoun is complex here, π takes # as its complement so only π is present on the highest head in the pronoun (this is quite generally the case in languages with weak PCC type effects), i.e. only π of EA is a sister to a projection of v in (23a), as a result of which v's # remains unvalued after Sisterhood agreement. At this point, v's person features can delete or not following a general approach to valued uninterpretable features where such features can be but need not be deleted right after valuing a matching unvalued feature (see also Bošković's 2011). On the derivation where both the EA and the IA are 1/2 person, v's person features don't delete. When v probes to value its number feature, which remained unvalued after Sisterhood agreement, it also values person features of the IA in (23b) (see Stegovec 2019 for details). All this is shown below:¹¹

(23) a.



¹⁰ Stegovec does not use Sisterhood agreement but essentially stipulates a condition to ensure that EA agrees first.

¹¹ (2[1] indicates that v is specified with both a participant '2' and a speaker '1' sub-feature, see Harley and Ritter 2002; details of the person hierarchy need not concern us here.



For Stegovec, when the EA is 1/2p and the IA a 3p pronoun, upon the EA merging and agreeing with v (actually vP under Sisterhood in our system), v's person feature is deleted (which, recall, is an option). Thus, when v probes the IA goal for its number feature, there is no person feature to value IA and the IA defaults to 3rd person. It is not possible to get 3rd person EA with a 1/2 person IA.

What is important for us is that the account crucially depends on the EA in SpecvP undergoing agreement with v before v probes IA, although IA enters the structure before EA (or we could get *3 EA and 1/2 IA, with v probing and valuing the IA before EA merger). In other words, what is crucial here in our terms is that Sisterhood agreement precedes Agree agreement.

Another case of this sort comes from Ik (based on Daniel's 2025 analysis of PCC-like effects for Case marking in Ik). In Ik, [1/2p] EA bleeds ACC-case on DO. When EA is [1p] or [2p], the verb agrees with EA; crucially, DO is Case-marked as NOM. But when EA is [3p], the verb agrees with EA, but DO is ACC. This is illustrated in (24).

- (24) a. $\eta k-i-\acute{a}$ $t\acute{o}b\acute{o}\eta-a=na$
 eat-1SG-a mush-NOM=this
 ‘**I** eat this meal mush.’
 b. $\eta k-id-\acute{a}$ $t\acute{o}b\acute{o}\eta-a=na$
 eat-2SG-a mush-NOM=this
 ‘**You** eat this meal mush.’
 c. ηka $t\acute{o}b\acute{o}\eta-\acute{a}=na$
 eat:3SG mush-ACC=this
 ‘**She** eats this meal mush.’

(Schrock 2017:527)

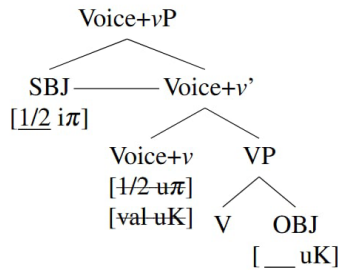
The pattern fits Sisterhood>Agree ordering. The following modifies Daniel (2025), to which the reader is referred to for a more detailed discussion. The agreement morphology is a minimal pronoun which, as before, is unvalued for person and gets valued under Sisterhood (as before, v is valued for person). Furthermore, all probes on X deactivate after a successful valuation cycle (condition referred to as X below).

When the DO is not ACC (see (25)), the EA merges with VoiceP/vP (nothing would change if this is simply vP), Voice/v bearing [1/2p] first undergoes Sisterhood agreement with the EA and values the EA with [1,2p]. The features on Voice/v, including Case, delete after valuation (given X—recall also

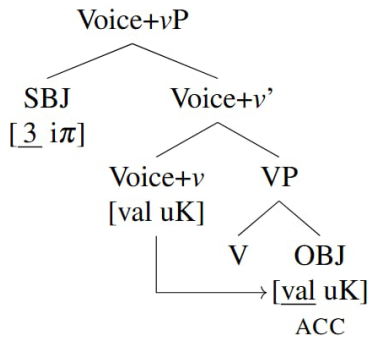
that valued uninterpretable features can be deleted). The DO then cannot receive [ACC] and gets default NOM.

When the DO is ACC-marked (26), the Voice/v head lacks any person features (which is an option in Ik). The EA merges with VoiceP. Subsequently, no Sisterhood agreement occurs and the EA defaults to [3p]. Since Voice/v did not undergo Agree, it is still active (X is irrelevant): it undergoes Agree with the lower DO and assigns [ACC] (Case is a valued uFeature on the traditional Case assigner, see Bošković 2011).

(25)



(26)



What is crucial is that we also have here a situation where a property of EA determines what happens with IA, i.e. agreement with/valuation of EA bleeds agreement with/valuation of IA, which can be easily captured with the Sisterhood>Agree ordering (for v), a result of which is that agreement with EA takes place before agreement with IA.

It is also worth noting that the current system makes possible a rather straightforward approach to the strong vs weak PCC distinction (PCC concerns co-occurrence restrictions on pronominal direct and indirect object clitics). Stegovec (2019) presents an account of this distinction where in the strong PCC, agreement between v and the higher object takes place at a distance, under Agree. With weak PCC, this Agree relation also takes place but cannot value all the relevant features of the pronoun for independent reasons (see Stegovec 2019 for details), which forces it to move to SpecvP where it undergoes another agreement relation. The analysis can be recast in very simple terms in the current system, where strong PCC involves Agree (at a distance), and Weak PCC involves (local) agreement under Sisterhood, with a simplification in that with weak PCC, there is no need for the agreement at the distance step, all we have is Agree agreement for strong PCC and Sisterhood agreement for weak PCC.

Summarizing, in this section we have seen a number of agreement paradigms which provide evidence that there are ordering effects between Agree agreement and Sisterhood agreement when the same head is involved in both, where in some cases we have a Sisterhood>Agree ordering and in some cases an Agree>Sisterhood ordering. This in itself provides evidence that both are needed; the fact that they can have different morphological realization even when the same head is involved provides

additional evidence that the two should be differentiated. We have also seen that the Sisterhood/Agree analysis makes possible a simplification of previous analyses that did not rely on Sisterhood.¹²

4. Beyond Spec-Head agreement

The Sisterhood cases discussed in the previous section involved what could be traditionally considered Spec-Head agreement. But it is not only traditional Spec-Head agreement cases that involve Sisterhood licensing. Recall that non-wh-movement cases of indeterminate licensing do not involve traditional SHA, or movement in fact, although they are unified now with the traditional SHA cases (through Sisterhood). The analysis can in fact be extended to other cases that do not involve traditional SHA, but where Sisterhood is also relevant, which will be discussed next.

4.1. The clitic/strong pronoun alternation

There is a clitic/strong pronoun alternation in SC where a particle, whose nature is pronominal, is added to what is considered a clitic form to get a strong form, as shown in (27), a partial paradigm which illustrates the general pattern.

- (27) a. me ('me' clitic (acc)) me+ne ('me' strong pronoun (acc))
 b. te ('you.sg' clitic (acc)) te+be ('you.sg' strong pronoun (acc))
 c. ga ('him', clitic (acc)) nje+ga ('him' strong pronoun (acc))
 d. ih ('them, clitic (acc)) nj+ih ('them' strong pronoun (acc))
 e. je/ju ('her' clitic (acc)) nju ('her' strong pronoun (acc))

I suggest (27) also involves licensing under Sisterhood. In particular, implementing the licensing along the lines of what was suggested above for wh-phrases, the suggestion is that *ga* in (27c) is the unvalued sister and *nje* the valued one. It values its sister, yielding a strong pronoun as the whole object.

Let us see how the valuation here can be implemented in more detail. Stegovec (2023) suggests that the clitic part, *ga* in (27c)/(28), is phi and Case features; *nje* is the (pronominal) root, which provides lexical stress hence is needed to form a prosodic word.

(28) *nje+ga*

Recall also that Stegovec (2019, 2020) argues that minimal pronouns/clitics are valued for gender and number, but not person, they receive the person feature value from *v*, which is the source of PCC effects. What is also important is that clitics are involved in PCC effects, strong pronouns are not. In light of all this, I suggest that strong pronouns are valued for person (hence they don't participate in PCC effects), which means that it is the non-clitic sister in (27)/(28) that is valued for person. Consider (29):

(29) **nje+ga** (him, acc, ga is the clitic part)

nje: valued for person, **ga** unvalued for person

the whole combination, **njega** (the strong pronoun), is valued for person

the clitic, **ga**, is not when not merged with **nje**, in that case it gets its valuation from *v*

¹²This is not the case only with the strong/weak PCC distinction but several other aspects of the Cyclic Agree/Stegovec/Daniel analyses that the discussion in section 3 relied on, which was not obvious from the above discussion since it adapted the works it was relying on to the current system (instead of giving the original analyses).

Both *nje* and *ga* have the person feature; *nje* values its sister, so that the whole combination is valued for person, which makes it ineligible for PCC effects, as discussed above. The valued sister is what makes stress assignment possible (see above); without the valued sister, stress assignment is not possible, as a result of which we get a clitic (which is unstressed).

There is an alternative analysis: when nothing is added, *ga* gets default valuation as [clitic]. The intuition that this is the default value comes from competition approaches to pronouns, where a clitic wins over a strong pronoun when the context doesn't specifically ask for the latter. I take this to mean that [clitic] is the default pronominal value. There is a subset (strong pronoun)-superset (clitic) relationship in the usage of strong pronouns and clitics. Thus, while a strong pronoun must be referential, a clitic may be referential or a bound variable (30). With strong pronouns, the referent must be human, with clitics it can be human or non-human (31)-(32).

- (30) a. Svako_i misli da ga_{i/j} Ana voli.
 everyone thinks that him(clitic) Ana loves
 b. Svako_i misli da Ana voli njega_{j/*i}.
 everyone thinks that Ana loves him(strong pronoun) (SC)
- (31) Ivan je oprao svoj auto_i a Marija ga_i nije oprala
 Ivan is washed his car and Marija him.clitic neg.aux washed
 'Ivan washed his car and Marija didn't wash it.'
- (32) *Ivan je oprao svoj auto_i a Marija njega_i nije oprala
 Ivan is washed his car and Marija him.st.pron neg.aux washed (SC)

Clitics have also been argued to have less structure; the default value is then the one that corresponds to the form with less structure and fewer semantic restrictions.

The default clitic value account also provides a fresh perspective on the long-standing and unresolved question: why clitics need to move.¹³ Consider Case. Default Case is typically not available in situ (if it were, Case filter effects would be voided), it is generally available in non-theta positions (see Caha 2024). Default Case involves valuing an unvalued Case feature with the default value for the feature (see Bošković 2011). This is exactly what I have suggested above happens with the valuation as [clitic]. I therefore suggest that just like default Case valuation is not possible in situ, i.e. in a theta-position, it is also not possible with default [clitic] valuation. Traditional "clitics" then need to undergo movement to be able to get the default [clitic] value for the relevant feature.¹⁴

4.2. Clitic/non-clitic alternation for auxiliaries

The Sisterhood licensing analysis can also be applied to clitic/non-clitic alternations for auxiliaries, which is illustrated below for SC (other languages show similar alternations, e.g. Basque and a number of other Slavic languages).

- (33) SC auxiliaries, 'be' present tense (a=clitic, a'=strong form (positive) a''=negative strong form...
 a. sam 1p.s a'. jesam a'' nisam
 b. si 2.p.s b'. jesi b'' nisi

¹³On why clitics must move, see Abels (2003), Bošković (2001, 2025b), Cardinaletti and Starke (1999), Migdalski (2015), Roberts (2010), Stjepanović (1999), among others.

¹⁴There is a parallel with indeterminates here. Recall that unlicensed indeterminates, like *ko* in (3a) (the wh-usage), must move, just like the unlicensed pronominal part (i.e. clitic). In both cases, the reason is valuation (though in a different way).

c. je	3p.s	c'. jeste	c'' nije
d. smo	1p.pl	d'. jesmo	d'' nismo
e. ste	2p.pl	e'. jeste	e'' niste
f. su	3p.pl	f'. jesu	f'' nisu

This paradigm can also be straightforwardly handled in terms of Sisterhood licensing, with one sister being the clitic, the other the root, just as in (27).¹⁵

4.3. Reflexives

A similar situation is found with reflexives, *se* being a clitic reflexive and *sebe* a non-clitic reflexive in SC (34). There may actually be a parallel with English here, where (35) may be formed on a par with SC (34):

(34) *se+be*

(35) *them vs themselves (them+selves)*

Bošković (2004, 1997) argues that English object pronouns are ambiguous between a clitic and a non-clitic form. To mention some arguments here, *allege* disallows ECM of nominals (36) and non-clitic pronouns, but allows it with clitic pronouns (37), evidence for which is provided by the fact that the ECMed pronoun in (37) cannot be stressed and coordinated (38), a typical clitic behavior (39). All this also holds for Q-float within PPs (40)/(42)/(43). (Note that object *it* is unambiguously a clitic (44); see Jovović (2023, 2024) for additional evidence for clitics in English).

(36) *Mary alleged Sue and Ann to have left

(37) Mary alleged **him** to have left

(38) *Mary never alleged **him** and **her** to have left

(39) *Je **le** et **la** rencontre tous les jours.

I him and her meet all the days

[intended] 'I meet him and her every day.'

(French)

(40) *Mary hates the students all.

(41) Mary hates them all.

(42) *Mary hates **THEM** all.

(43) *Mary hates **you**, **him** and **her** all.

(44) a. Mary turned *it* down.

b. *Mary turned down it.

c. *Mary turned down IT.

Returning to (34)-(35), *themselves* in (35) may be built from the clitic *them*, in which case we would have a similar situation as with SC (34), where one sister (*se*) is a clitic (same for *herself*, *yourself*); this is clear with *itself*, where *it* is unambiguously a clitic. Furthermore, if possessive pronominals within DP

¹⁵What is also worth noticing here is that, in contrast to the pronominal case, there is no different root for different person here, i.e. the root does not alternate depending on the person. This actually makes sense. While in the pronominal case, the clitic part is valued either by the root (in the case of a strong pronoun) or *v*, where in the latter case the phi-features of the valuator are not morphologically realized (there is no object agreement), in this case the root basically is *v*.

cannot be clitics,¹⁶ we could explain why there are no possessive reflexives, like **hissself* (*myself* is possible but not in **myself's car*).

At any rate, Sisterhood licensing may also be involved in English reflexives, with *selves* being licensed under Sisterhood licensing with merger with *them* in *themselves* (note that the reflexive sister is unvalued for person, while *them* is valued for person¹⁷).

5. Sisterhood Case

In GB, Case was assumed to be assigned under government. That involved three configurations: *Mary* in (45) was assumed to be assigned nominative in a Spec-head relation with Infl, *Sue* was assumed to be assigned accusative in a head-complement relation with the verb and finally, *John* in (46) was assumed to be assigned accusative in a configuration that motivated government: head-Spec of its complement (the Case assigner being the verb *believe*, with *John* assumed to be located in the Spec of its IP complement). The latter was later reanalyzed in early minimalism in terms of object shift (e.g. Lasnik and Saito 1991), with *John* receiving accusative in a Spec-head relation after moving to SpecAgroP.

(45) *Mary likes Sue.*

(46) *Mary believes John to know French.*

Recall now that, as argued extensively above, Spec-head licensing actually involves Sisterhood licensing. This means that all Case-licensing in (45)-(46) takes place in a Sisterhood relation.

While there is rather strong evidence for overt object shift in (46) (see e.g. the summary of relevant arguments from the literature in Bošković 2004), it is less clear whether *Sue* in (45) undergoes overt object shift, with some authors arguing that object shift is optional in this case (again, see the references in Bošković 2004). At any rate, in some languages direct objects can receive an inherent, lexically-specified Case, which is standardly assumed to be licensed under theta-role assignment from the verb (see e.g. Chomsky 1986). More precisely, it is standardly assumed that inherent Case is licensed only in a traditional head-complement relation (which is also a Sisterhood relation), which is then anyway needed for Case-licensing.

Consider also in this respect Kinande. Kinande has object shift only in ECM configurations (see Bošković 2016), where the relevant nominal appears preceding an agreement morpheme, indicating movement to SpecAgroP (this is not the case with simple transitives, where there is no object agreement morpheme, see Schneider-Zioga 1995). In other words, in Kinande only the accusative nominal in cases similar to (46) undergoes object shift, the accusative nominal in (45) doesn't, as indicating by the presence and positioning with respect to the object agreement morpheme.

Kinande thus clearly disallows Case-licensing at a distance. In other words, Kinande is a rather clear case where only Case-licensing under Sisterhood is allowed. The current analysis in fact unifies the two configurations for Case-licensing in Kinande, Spec-head and head-complement, within a single licensing configuration, namely Sisterhood (sister to V or vP).

It is also worth noting here that head-complement was in fact one of the core licensing configurations in the GB theory, since the head governs its complement. All such cases are now resurrected and recast as involving Sisterhood licensing, accusative Case-licensing from (45) representing one such case.

¹⁶Possibly because clitics must move and they cannot undergo movement from this position given the impossibility of left-branch extraction in English (note object clitics in English do move, see Bošković 2004, cf. (45) vs (46)).

¹⁷There is no issue with clitics being valued for person in English given that there are no PCC effects in English.

6. Broader issues

The Sisterhood agreement vs Agree agreement distinction argued for here is not completely new, it is a different framing, with a different perspective, of long-lasting distinctions, which in itself shows that a distinction along these lines is needed. In early minimalism (Chomsky 1993), there was a distinction between strong and weak features, where the former requires checking in overt syntax, which means that only the former affects word order, and requires a local checking relation in overt syntax, which is reminiscent of the Sisterhood vs Agree difference. In Chomsky (2000, 2001), there is a distinction among agreeing heads (i.e. heads that undergo Agree) in terms of whether or not they have an edge feature, with the edge feature resulting in creation of a Sisterhood relation. So, a distinction along these lines has always been needed; the particular framing of the distinction in the current work, however, enables us to have a broader empirical coverage, to include cases that do not involve a traditional Spec-Head agreement configuration.

Another point worth emphasizing is the ordering of the Sisterhood and Agree licensing—we have seen that there is a specific order between them when the same head is involved in both, it can be either Sisterhood>Agree or Agree>Sisterhood. It should be noted that the effects of the former cannot be captured in alternative approaches like Chomsky (2000) and Béjar and Řezáč (2009), which due to their architecture allow only Agree>Sisterhood. In Chomsky (2000), in (47), X and Y undergo Agree. Following that, if X is specified with having an edge feature, Y will undergo movement to SpecXP, so we can only have Agree>Sisterhood.

(47) X (edge feature) Y
 | _____ | (Agree)

In Béjar and Řezáč's (2009) Cyclic Agree, a probe P on X first searches its c-command domain; only if the probe fails its search in its c-command domain, P re-projects on XP and searches again, where SpecXP is now in the c-command domain of P on XP. This again gives us only (the counterpart of) Agree>Sisterhood, which we have seen is empirically inadequate.¹⁸

A question now arises, why do we have the exact syntactic licensing configurations discussed above. Thus, why do we have Sisterhood licensing? First, this is how every element enters the structure, so sisterhood is simply unavoidable. It is not surprising that the unavoidable configuration gets additional usages, as with c-command and syntactic feature licensing (regarding the latter, recall also that this is the most local syntactic licensing configuration). There is also additional functional motivation for it which concerns Specifiers (given that Specifiers are involved in Sisterhood licensing, as discussed above).

Dadan (2019) observes that diachronic changes very often involve loss of Specifiers (e.g. regarding question formation, the diachronic change always proceeds wh-movement-to-wh-in-situ, never the other way round). In that context (given that Specifiers are clearly dispreferred, see Dadan 2019 and Bošković

¹⁸While in section 3 I have given representative examples of both Sisterhood>Agree and Agree>Sisterhood, the fact is that the latter is more common. It is possible that something along the lines of Pesetsky's (1989) Earliness is relevant here, Agree being preferred since it can be done earlier than Sisterhood (unless Sisterhood is done in a head-complement relation). What is also noteworthy is that, as we have seen above, Sisterhood licensing often results in richer morphology than Agree licensing. As noted by Robin Jenkins (p.c.), this makes sense intuitively: what we may have here is something like a minimize-your-exponent strategy for the preferred option (Agree); when the dispreferred option is used, there is a tendency to show that with more morphology (admittedly, these are merely intuitions; they are hard to formalize since what we are dealing with here are tendencies, not absolutes).

2021 for different explanations for this), a question arises, why don't all Specifiers get lost? That would essentially lead to the loss of movement, so the question is broader: why do we have movement in the first place? Chomsky's (2000) answer is that this concerns "externally imposed legibility conditions". More precisely, the reason is essentially functional, or more broadly non-syntactic: to be able to express notions that go beyond the basic argument structure (which is what we would have without Specs): more complex semantic notions involving issues like scope/scopal ambiguities, pragmatic notions concerning things like topic/focus interpretation, specificity..., in fact even argument structure beyond a simple predicate with one internal argument requires a specifier (see also Dadan 2019, Bošković 2021¹⁹).

From this perspective, a more pressing question arises: why do we have Agree? None of the above factors that motivate Specs/Sisterhood apply with Agree. There is an acknowledgment that strictly formal mechanisms should be disfavored in Chomsky's (1995) position on Agr, where he argues for eliminating Agr (i.e. agreement phrases) on the grounds that this is a strictly formal element which does not contribute to interpretation. But why do we then have Agree? It is a strictly formal operation that doesn't contribute to interpretation. The functional considerations that apply to Specs/Sisterhood/movement discussed above also do not apply to Agree. It appears then that Chomsky's reasons for eliminating Agr phrases should also carry over to Agree. Recall also that Sisterhood is also how every element enters the structure (this happens through creation of a Sisterhood relation). This also does not apply to Agree. So, it appears then that the question should not be why we have Sisterhood but why we have Agree.

7. Conclusion

In conclusion, I have argued that Sisterhood needs to be admitted as a feature-licensing configuration (features/elements can be lexically specified regarding whether they are licensed through unselective binding, Agree, or Sisterhood), which is implemented through prominent feature sharing involved in labeling. For the general importance of sisterhood, the reader is also referred to Epstein (1999), who shows that sisterhood is involved in c-command—you c-command what you are merged with, which is your sister (and what it dominates). Sisterhood is also how every element enters the structure—it is then not surprising that it is important, as the discussion in this paper has confirmed.

The account proposed in the paper was shown to explain and unify a number of phenomena, like indeterminate licensing (in sub-wh system languages), wh-movement in languages like English, the EPP, clitic-strong pronoun (more generally strong/weak element) alternations, ordering of agreement effects, certain Case effects... Traditional Spec-head agreement was quite generally recast as licensing under Sisterhood (though not all relevant Sisterhood licensing involves traditional Spec-head agreement). We have also seen evidence that Sisterhood licensing and Agree licensing can occur in either order when the same head is involved in both.²⁰ Importantly, this is not possible in alternatives like Chomsky (2000), Béjar and Řezáč (2009), where what is called Agree here architecturally has to precede the counterpart of current Sisterhood, which means that Sisterhood>Agree effects cannot be captured.

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¹⁹Some of these may have led to the development of formal requirements.

²⁰There are other empirical arguments for both orderings, what was presented in section 3 was merely representative of the ordering effects.

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